

LIVING | CHHATTISGARHIA OLYMPICS

# FASTER, HIGHER, STRONGER... IN CHHATTISGARH

**The Bhupesh Baghel-led Congress government hosts the state's first-ever Chhattisgarhia Olympics ostensibly to promote traditional Indian sports among its people. It's not all sporting spirit, though. The event is also intended as a political outreach a year ahead of the assembly polls**

By Rahul Noronha

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**A RUNNING COMMENTARY ON THE** loudspeaker punctuates the crowd's cheering—shrill, loud and spirited—as two sides line up against each other, one ready to raid and the other to defend. When a player from the raiding side crosses the mid line, drawn crudely on the ground, the cheering only grows louder. The charger lunges towards her four opponents, chanting '*kabaddi-kabaddi*' without pausing for breath. The defenders are ready, swiftly averting each of the raider's attempts to tag them. Finally, one leaps forward and holds the raider tightly by the waist. Another grabs a leg. The remaining two block her way back to safety. The game is over. Smiling and laughing, the members of the two teams—in red, blue, green and other colourful cotton *saris*—greet each other as a bunch of kids, who had been following